Research Essay Rubric

Analysis

High Distinction
The essay demonstrates an excellent understanding of the problem captured by the essay question. It analyses the key elements of the essay question and discusses multiple lines of arguments, while articulating a clear answer to the question asked. The essay carries out a persuasive and well-sustained analysis, engaging with key theories and arguments, avoiding superficial description and demonstrating strong critical thinking skills. The annotated source demonstrates excellent critical engagement, includes three or more annotations, and all the comments are clearly and accurately linked to specific points in the essay.

Distinction
The essay demonstrates a very good understanding of the problem captured by the essay question. It analyses some of the key elements of the essay question and identifies multiple lines of arguments, while articulating a clear answer to the question asked. The essay engages with some of the key theories and arguments, avoiding superficial description and demonstrating some critical thinking skills. The annotated source demonstrates very good critical engagement, includes three or more annotations, and all the comments are linked to specific points in the essay.

Credit
The essay demonstrates a good understanding of the problem captured by the essay question. It articulates a clear answer to the question asked. The essay critically analyses some of the key theories and arguments, avoiding superficial description. The annotated source demonstrates good critical engagement, includes at least three annotations, but the links to the essay are not always precise.

Pass
The essay demonstrates some understanding of the problem captured by the essay question. It discusses some of the relevant issues, touching upon some of the key theories and arguments. The annotated source demonstrates some critical engagement, includes fewer than three annotations, and the link between the comments and the essay is thin and/or unclear.

Fail
The essay does not demonstrate a sufficient understanding of the problem captured by the essay question. It fails to answer the essay question or is completely off topic. The attached source is absent, or is attached but there are no annotations, and/or there is no real attempt to link the comments to the essay.

Research

High Distinction
The essay engages with several scholarly contributions that are relevant to answering the essay question, including both sources provided in the reading list and acquired by the student engaging in independent research (published academic journal articles, book chapters, etc). Non-academic sources such as newspaper articles and government reports should be used sparingly only if necessary and to provide context, always in addition to scholarly research. The student identifies an academic source that most substantially underpins the essay's central argument.

Distinction
The essay engages with some scholarly contributions that are (mostly) relevant to answering the essay question, including both sources provided in the reading list and acquired by the student engaging in independent research (published academic journal articles, book chapters, etc). Non-academic sources such as newspaper articles and government reports should be used sparingly only if necessary and to provide context, always in addition to scholarly research. The student identifies an appropriate source that is important for the essay's central argument.

Credit
The essay includes references to some scholarly contributions that are (mostly) relevant to answering the essay question, including both sources provided in the reading list and acquired by the student engaging in independent research (published academic journal articles, book chapters, etc). Non-academic sources such as newspaper articles and government reports should be used sparingly only if necessary and to provide context, always in addition to scholarly research. The student identifies a relevant source, somehow linked to the essay's central argument.

Pass
The essay considers some of the scholarly contributions included in the reading list that are relevant to answering the essay question (published academic journal articles, book chapters, etc). Non-academic sources such as newspaper articles and government reports should be used sparingly only if necessary and to provide context, always in addition to scholarly research. The student identifies a source with limited or unclear connection with the essay's central argument.

Fail
The essay fails to demonstrate a sufficient engagement with the academic literature. The essay uses academic sources that are not relevant to answering the essay question and/or information from unreliable sources. The student fails to identify a source to annotate, or the source identified bears little relevance to the essay's central argument.

Structure

High Distinction
The essay displays a very clear structure which mirrors the development of the core argument. The overall structure of the paper is coherent, and the different parts of the essay are logically connected, with a good flow.

Distinction
The essay displays a clear structure which mostly overlaps with the development of the core argument. Appropriate signposting connects the different parts of the essay.

Credit
The essay displays a clear structure which tends to follow the development of the core argument. The overall structure of the paper is mostly coherent and some signposting is present.

Pass
The overall structure of the essay is not fully clear and/or coherent. Some arguments might be only sketched.

Fail
The essay lacks a clear structure and fails to carry out a coherent analysis relevant to the issues discussed.

Style

High Distinction
Excellent written expression. The essay is clearly written, without convoluted syntax, grammatical errors, or typos. It complies with the Australian Guide to Legal Citation (4th edition). Footnotes are only used for references, and the essay includes a bibliography, which is formatted in accordance with rule 1.13 of the AGLC 4. All instructions are precisely followed.

Distinction
Very good written expression. The essay is clearly written, without convoluted syntax, grammatical errors, or typos. It complies with the Australian Guide to Legal Citation (4th edition). Footnotes are only used for references, and the essay includes a bibliography, which is formatted in accordance with rule 1.13 of the AGLC 4. All instructions are followed, but with some imprecisions.

Credit
Good written expression. The essay is clearly written, without convoluted syntax, grammatical errors, or typos. It complies with the Australian Guide to Legal Citation (4th edition). Footnotes

are only used for references, and the essay includes a bibliography, which must be formatted in accordance with rule 1.13 of the AGLC 4. Some minor instructions are not followed.

Pass

Acceptable written expression. The essay is written without grammatical errors, or typos. It complies with the Australian Guide to Legal Citation (4th edition). Footnotes are only used for references, and the essay includes a bibliography, formatted in accordance with rule 1.13 of the AGLC 4. Some major instructions are not followed.

Fail

Poor written expression. The essay includes grammatical errors and/or typos. It does not comply with the Australian Guide to Legal Citation (4th edition). Footnotes are not used and/or not used properly (including not for referencing). There is no bibliography and/or the bibliography is not formatted in accordance with rule 1.13 of the AGLC 4. Several instructions are not followed.